



Airtable as Source of Truth

Living Design · Walmart Commerce Platform · 2024-2025

ROLE

Lead Designer, Living Design

TIMELINE

Aug 2024 – Nov 2025

SCOPE

17 themes · iOS · Android · Web





No shared source of truth.

Everyone was working alone.

DESIGN

Figma was restricted

The core team locked down their files — no direct access, no token contributions, no syncing.

ENGINEERING

GitHub was fragmented

iOS, Android, and Web each maintained their own token repos with no shared inheritance model.

COMMERCE

Commerce needs were unmet

Commerce teams needed branding tokens, extended components, and multi-org support the core didn't provide.



The Human Cost

The cost wasn't just inefficiency. It was eroded trust.

- Teams were doing the same work twice — every team kept their own copy of the same tokens.
- Designers and engineers couldn't trust they were looking at the same thing. Design decisions were constantly re-litigated during implementation.
- Commerce teams had no clear place to go for answers, so they built in isolation — more inconsistency, more overhead with every release.
- Manual exports took 2-3 days per update with a ~15% error rate. Rollbacks were painful for everyone.



Airtable as Source of Truth.

Tool selection should follow team behavior — not the other way around.

× **Figma**

Access restricted. No versioning. Can't support cross-team inheritance at scale.

× **GitHub**

Requires engineering skills to safely edit. Design ownership breaks down in JSON files.

✓ **Why Airtable**

- Designers will actually use it correctly at scale — relational tables, not JSON files in a repo
- Engineers get a reliable API. One source, all three platform outputs. Column schema is a frozen contract.
- Inheritance model enables 17-brand theming without duplication across 650+ tokens

Airtable → Style Dictionary → GitHub Actions →



Designer updates a value → 10 minutes later it's live in production across all platforms

17 brands. One base. Each layer defines only its overrides.



01 LD Base — Primitives

100% shared

650+ tokens. Raw values — hex, px, font sizes. Shared by every brand.

02 Semantic Layer

~90% inherited

Alias tokens map intent to primitives — colorTextDefault → gray-900.

03 WCP Theme

~20% override

Commerce-specific overrides. Sam's Club and Walmart+ branch from here.

04 Tenant Overrides

~10% override

Brand-specific. Cashi, Walmart Business, Bodega. Only what's unique.

When LD Base updates, all 17 tenants receive the change automatically — no manual propagation required.



The Safety Net

347 tests. If it breaks, the pipeline stops — not the product

347

automated
tests per sync

Alias Integrity

Tokens referencing tokens that no longer exist create silent failures on native platforms — nearly impossible to debug without a full audit.

Hex-to-Token Purity

100% of color values must resolve through the alias chain. No hardcoded hex values — they undermine the entire governance model.

Semantic Versioning

Breaking changes → major versions. New features → minor. Simple updates → patches. Teams control when to upgrade.



Design changes reach production in 10 minutes.

Zero coordination. Zero errors.

95%

Faster deployment

2-3 days → 10 min

0%

Error rate

347 automated tests

17

Brand themes

All self-service

650+

Tokens managed

Single source



Designers work in Airtable.
Engineers consume versioned
tokens.
~~No coordination needed.~~

The approach became the reference architecture for Cashi, Walmart Business, and Bodega onboarding.

What's next: Automated dynamic SVG theming for illustrations and brand assets.